Policy & Strategy Lab

Detailed 20-Day Curriculum

Stage 4 of 12 · Version 1.0 · 10 November 2026

This is the full teaching sequence. It follows the architecture approved in principle in the Course Concept Note: one anchor tool per day, learned to independent use; at most two or three supporting tools, demonstrated only; one theory link where it changes the analysis; one group activity; and one worksheet applied to each participant's own case. The seven-step process governs Weeks 1 to 3. Bardach and Patashnik's eightfold path, with Moore's strategic triangle, governs Week 4.

The programme at a glance

Day	Weekday	Theme	Anchor tool	Worksheet
1	Mon	Problems, clients and decisions	Problem, symptom, cause and solution sort	1.1
2	Tue	Defining the problem	Problem Definition Canvas	1.2
3	Wed	Structuring with issue trees	Issue tree (MECE)	2.1
4	Thu	Finding causes	Problem tree	2.2
5	Fri	Systems and scope lock (Gate 1)	Causal loop diagram	2.3
6	Mon	Jurisdiction, money and delivery	Delivery chain map	3.1
7	Tue	Actors and political economy	Power-interest map with absent voices	3.2
8	Wed	Prioritising issues	Pruning matrix: size of effect against ability to influence	4.1
9	Thu	Hypotheses	Hypothesis register	4.2
10	Fri	The workplan (Gate 2)	Workplan matrix: hypothesis, question, analysis, source, deadline	4.3
11	Mon	Finding and judging evidence	Source reliability assessment	5.1
12	Tue	What the numbers say	Disaggregation and comparison in a spreadsheet	5.2
13	Wed	Experience and comparison	Comparative case matrix	5.3
14	Thu	Testing the hypotheses	Hypothesis testing matrix	6.1
15	Fri	Synthesis and the diagnostic memo (Gate 3)	Pyramid Principle with SCQA	6.2
16	Mon	Generating options	How Might We questions with a journey map	7.1
17	Tue	Choosing between options	Options appraisal matrix with a distributional row	7.2
18	Wed	Designing for delivery	Theory of change	8.1
19	Thu	Measurement and the pitch (Gate 4)	Indicator framework (indicator tree)	9.1
20	Fri	The defence	Panel presentation and defence	10.1

Weekly rhythm

Days	Purpose
Monday to Wednesday	Learn and apply
Thursday (Days 4, 9, 14, 19)	Challenge: a longer simulation, battle or red team
Friday (Days 5, 10, 15) and Day 19	Gate submission and pod peer review

The default two-hour session

Minutes	Activity
0 to 10	Opening problem or retrieval question
10 to 35	Concept
35 to 55	Demonstration on the Madhyapur spine case
55 to 90	Group activity
90 to 110	Individual workbook application to own case
110 to 120	Debrief and exit task

Gate days shorten the concept block to make room for 40 minutes of pod peer review. Days 11 to 13 run as research studios. Day 20 is given over to presentations and defence. Each day's exact plan is in its section below and in the Instructor Guide.

Day 1: Problems, clients and decisions

Week 1, Define and structure · Monday

Central question. What does it mean to solve a public problem systematically, and who are we solving it for?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has sorted statements about your candidate cases into problems, symptoms, causes and solutions, and named a provisional decision-making role for each.

Learning objectives.

1. Explain how the Lab works: one case, one shared method, four gates.
2. Distinguish a problem from a symptom, a cause and a solution.
3. Name a decision-making role and the decision it faces.
4. Explain why public problems are harder to define than a firm's.

Element	Content
Competencies	A1, A3, A4
Key concepts	Problem, symptom, cause and solution; Decision-maker and decision; Wicked problems; The seven-step process; The eightfold path
Anchor tool	Problem, symptom, cause and solution sort
Supporting tools	The seven steps and the eightfold path compared; Naming the decision-maker
Theory link	Rittel and Webber ("Dilemmas in a General Theory of Planning", Policy Sciences, 1973): Whose definition of the problem are you adopting, and what would count as solved?
Indian policy example	Welfare access in Indian districts: many schemes exist, yet the exclusion of eligible families is a recurring concern in audits and research. The problem is easy to misstate as a lack of awareness among citizens.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur. Candidate: waste segregation. Statements: most households hand over mixed waste (problem); the landfill is close to full (symptom); crews tip separated bags into one compartment (candidate cause); give every household two bins (solution). Problem statement: most households in Madhyapur's residential wards do not hand over waste separated into the streams the 2016 rules require. Role: Municipal Commissioner. Decision: which compliance strategy to fund next financial year.
Live group activity	The ten-minute problem challenge: Experience how quickly a group jumps to solutions, then rebuild the problem properly. (35 minutes)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 1.1, Sorting your candidate cases
Submission	Worksheet 1.1 with three sorted candidates and a provisional choice, by the start of Day 2.
Assessment	Not graded. Checked at the start of Day 2 for completion and for causes or solutions hidden in problem statements (tracker code PF1).
Independent work	Finish Worksheet 1.1. For the candidate you are most likely to choose, open two public data sources and note what each covers, at what level (state, district or city) and for which year. Bring both to Day 2. About 45 minutes.
Essential reading	Rittel and Webber, "Dilemmas in a General Theory of Planning" (1973). Read the ten properties of wicked problems.
Optional reading	Conn and McLean, Bulletproof Problem Solving (2018), chapter 1.; Bardach and Patashnik, A Practical Guide for Policy Analysis, part I, step one: define the problem.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 25 | How the Lab works | | 25 to 45 | Problem, symptom, cause, solution | | 45 to 80 | Activity: ten-minute challenge | | 80 to 105 | Own case: candidate sort | | 105 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 2: Defining the problem

Week 1, Define and structure · Tuesday

Central question. How do we turn a broad concern into a problem statement precise enough to analyse and act on?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has completed the Problem Definition Canvas for your case and submitted the Case Approval Form.

Learning objectives.

1. Write a problem statement that names population, place, institution, period and a measure of success.
2. Bound the scope: what is in, and what is deliberately left out.
3. Record competing framings and adopt one for a stated reason.
4. Check your case against the feasibility tests.

Element	Content
Competencies	A2, A3, A4
Key concepts	Problem Definition Canvas; Scope and boundaries; Current and desired condition; Competing framings; Case feasibility; Capabilities
Anchor tool	Problem Definition Canvas
Supporting tools	5W1H precision test; The case-narrowing ladder
Theory link	Amartya Sen (Development as Freedom, 1999): Are you measuring access to a resource, or what people are actually able to do with it?
Indian policy example	A household may hold a ration card and still be unable to draw its rations if the fair price shop is open only when the household cannot travel. A measure built only on card coverage would miss the problem.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	See the Madhyapur canvas on the Day 2 slides. Problem statement: most households in Madhyapur's residential wards hand over waste unseparated, contrary to the 2016 rules; the Municipal Commissioner must decide which compliance strategy to fund next financial year.
Live group activity	Problem reframing lab: Turn vague public concerns into precise, decision-focused statements, then test them against each other. (30 minutes)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 1.2, Problem Definition Canvas and Case Approval Form
Submission	Canvas and Case Approval Form by the end of Day 2. Provisional approval is returned by Day 3.
Assessment	Case Approval Form scored on the feasibility rubric: nine criteria from 0 to 2, at least 12 of 18, with no zero on evidence, institutional clarity or ethical safety. Provisional approval by Day 3.
Independent work	Revise your canvas after the gallery walk. Find the published qualitative or field-based source the Case Approval Form asks for, such as an audit report, social audit, committee report or field study, and note its two most relevant findings. About 45 minutes.
Essential reading	Bardach and Patashnik, A Practical Guide for Policy Analysis, part I, step one: define the problem.
Optional reading	Sen, Development as Freedom (1999), introduction and chapter 1.; PRS Legislative Research: browse the bill and budget summaries for your sector.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 30 | Concept: precision and scope | | 30 to 50 | Demonstration: canvas on Madhyapur | | 50 to 80 | Activity: problem reframing lab | | 80 to 110 | Own case: canvas and approval form | | 110 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 3: Structuring with issue trees

Week 1, Define and structure · Wednesday

Central question. How do we break a complex problem into questions we can actually answer?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has built a three-level MECE issue tree for your case, written and sealed a working answer, and started your Analyst's Ledger.

Learning objectives.

1. Apply the two MECE tests to a set of branches.
2. Build an issue tree to three levels that ends in answerable questions.
3. Distinguish a question-led tree from a hypothesis-led tree.
4. Write a sealed working answer of no more than 100 words.

Element	Content
Competencies	B1, B2, B3, F4
Key concepts	Mutually exclusive, collectively exhaustive; Issue tree; Splitting logic; Driver tree; Hypothesis-led tree; Sealed working answer; Analyst's Ledger
Anchor tool	Issue tree (MECE)
Supporting tools	Hypothesis-led tree; The sealed working answer; The Analyst's Ledger
Theory link	None today.
Indian policy example	A state scheme that gives bicycles to girls entering secondary school can be split by supply and demand: was the bicycle offered and delivered, and was it taken up? Each branch leads to different evidence and different decision-makers.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur root question: why do most households hand over mixed waste? Level one, split by stage: households do not separate; collection mixes separated waste; separated waste has nowhere to go; rules are not enforced or rewarded. Each branch ends in two or three answerable questions (see the Day 3 slides).
Live group activity	The issue tree challenge: Build a MECE tree under time pressure, then defend its logic against another pod. (35 minutes)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 2.1, Issue tree and sealed working answer
Submission	Worksheet 2.1 by the start of Day 4. Send the sealed answer to the instructor separately; it is not marked and not opened until Day 20.
Assessment	Part of Gate 1 (Day 5). Feedback uses competencies B1 and B2 and tracker codes ST1 and ST2.
Independent work	Show your tree to someone outside the course and ask them to find a gap. Revise it. Add one more answerable question to your weakest branch. About 40 minutes.
Essential reading	Conn and McLean, Bulletproof Problem Solving (2018), the chapter on disaggregating problems with logic trees.
Optional reading	Minto, The Pyramid Principle, the chapter on grouping ideas (edition to confirm).

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 30 | Concept: MECE and trees | | 30 to 50 | Demonstration: Madhyapur tree | | 50 to 85 | Activity: issue tree challenge | | 85 to 110 | Own case: tree and sealed answer | | 110 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 4: Finding causes

Week 1, Define and structure · Thursday

Central question. How do we move from describing a problem to explaining why it exists?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has built a problem tree for your case that separates symptoms from proximate and structural causes, and tested a Five Whys chain against it.

Learning objectives.

1. Separate symptoms, proximate causes and structural causes.
2. State the mechanism behind each causal link.
3. Use Five Whys and the fishbone to generate candidate causes without treating them as proof.
4. Distinguish correlation, causation and mechanism.

Element	Content
Competencies	C1, C2, C5
Key concepts	Symptoms, proximate and structural causes; Causal mechanism; Five Whys; Fishbone diagram; Correlation and causation; Multiple causation
Anchor tool	Problem tree
Supporting tools	Five Whys; Fishbone diagram
Theory link	None today.
Indian policy example	Foundational learning: low reading levels in early grades are commonly linked to several candidate causes at once, including teaching at grade level rather than at the child's level, multigrade classrooms, home language and attendance. A single-cause story rarely survives the evidence.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur core problem: most households hand over mixed waste. Proximate cause: separating seems pointless, because households see crews tip separated bags together. Structural cause: the contract pays by the tonne, not by stream. Effects: a near-full landfill, lost recyclables, unsafe work.
Live group activity	Root cause investigation: Separate symptoms, proximate causes and structural causes in an unfamiliar case, and defend the links. (45 minutes (Thursday challenge))
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 2.2, Problem tree for your case
Submission	Worksheet 2.2 by the start of Day 5, for inclusion in Gate 1.
Assessment	Part of Gate 1. Feedback uses competencies C1, C2 and C5 and tracker codes CA1 and CA2.
Independent work	Revise your problem tree after the challenge. For your two most important causal links, write what evidence would show the link to be wrong. About 45 minutes.
Essential reading	Andrews, Pritchett and Woolcock, Building State Capability (2017), the chapter on problem deconstruction, which uses the fishbone diagram (open access).
Optional reading	Pratham, Annual Status of Education Report: the summary of the most recent national report, for the common case.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 30 | Concept: levels of cause | | 30 to 45 | Demonstration: Madhyapur problem tree | | 45 to 90 | Thursday challenge: root cause investigation | | 90 to 110 | Own case: problem tree | | 110 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 5: Systems and scope lock

Week 1, Define and structure · Friday

Central question. What keeps the problem in place, and is our case now ready for analysis?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has drawn a causal loop diagram for your case, checked the obvious fix for unintended consequences, and submitted Gate 1.

Learning objectives.

1. Identify a reinforcing or balancing loop that sustains the problem.
2. Mark the polarity of each link.
3. Anticipate at least two unintended consequences of the obvious fix.
4. Lock the scope of your case and submit the problem diagnostic.

Element	Content
Competencies	C3, C4, B2
Key concepts	Feedback loops; Reinforcing and balancing loops; Polarity; Delays; Unintended consequences; Isomorphic mimicry; Scope lock
Anchor tool	Causal loop diagram
Supporting tools	Unintended consequences check; Gate 1 pod peer review
Theory link	Andrews, Pritchett and Woolcock (Building State Capability, 2017): Would the obvious fix copy the form of a programme that worked elsewhere without the capability behind it?
Indian policy example	Banning street vending on main roads to ease congestion can push vendors into side streets, raise informal payments and move the congestion. The Street Vendors (Protection of Livelihood and Regulation of Street Vending) Act, 2014 makes the design of such measures a legal as well as a practical question.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur loop: crews mix separated waste, households see the mixing, households stop separating, more mixed waste reaches crews, and so on (reinforcing). Obvious fix: fines. Unintended effects: roadside dumping; a burden on small homes.
Live group activity	The unintended consequences challenge: Find how a sensible-looking intervention could make things worse, and why. (25 minutes)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 2.3, Causal loop and the Gate 1 diagnostic
Submission	Gate 1 diagnostic (Worksheets 1.2, 2.1, 2.2 and 2.3, revised) by the end of Day 5. Feedback returned by Day 7.
Assessment	Gate 1: detailed feedback on domains A, B and C under the five feedback headings. Formative; patterns recorded in the Analyst Development Tracker.
Independent work	Catch up and rest. If you have time, identify the institutions responsible for your problem: which ministry, state department and local body are involved? Bring notes to Day 6. About 30 minutes.
Essential reading	Andrews, Pritchett and Woolcock, Building State Capability (2017), the chapter on capability traps and isomorphic mimicry (open access).
Optional reading	Meadows, Donella H. Thinking in Systems: A Primer (2008), chapter 1.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 25 | Concept: loops and polarity | | 25 to 40 | Demonstration: Madhyapur loop | | 40 to 65 | Activity: unintended consequences | | 65 to 105 | Gate 1: pod peer review | | 105 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 6: Jurisdiction, money and delivery

Week 2, Situate and prioritise · Monday

Central question. Who has the authority to act on this problem, where does the money come from, and where does delivery break down?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has mapped the jurisdiction, funding route and delivery chain for your case, and run a PESTLE check on your issue tree.

Learning objectives.

1. Locate your subject in the Seventh Schedule, and in the Eleventh or Twelfth Schedule where relevant.
2. Trace how the activity is funded: scheme, budget head and cost sharing.
3. Map the delivery chain from policy-maker to citizen and mark the likely break point.
4. Use PESTLE to check your issue tree for missing factors.

Element	Content
Competencies	D1, D2, D3, D5
Key concepts	Legislative authority, administrative control and funding; Union, State and Concurrent Lists; Eleventh and Twelfth Schedules; Central sector and centrally sponsored schemes; Delivery chain; PESTLE
Anchor tool	Delivery chain map
Supporting tools	The Seventh Schedule and local government schedules; Reading a budget line; PESTLE as a completeness check
Theory link	Lant Pritchett and Devesh Kapur ("Is India a Flailing State?" (2009); "Why Does the Indian State Both Fail and Succeed?" (2020)): At which link in the delivery chain does intent at the top stop becoming action on the ground?
Indian policy example	Solid waste management appears in the Twelfth Schedule, added by the 74th Amendment, as a function states may devolve to municipalities. Public health and sanitation, and local government, are State List subjects. Union influence arrives through missions such as Swachh Bharat Mission (Urban) 2.0 and through Finance Commission grants.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur: solid waste management is a Twelfth Schedule function; public health and sanitation and local government are State List subjects. Funding: the mission's central and state shares, Finance Commission grants to urban local bodies and the corporation's own revenue. Chain: Union ministry, state department, corporation, ward staff, contractor crews, households. Likely break: between ward staff and crews.
Live group activity	Follow the money: Trace how a public service is authorised, funded and delivered, from the Constitution to the citizen. (30 minutes)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 3.1, Jurisdiction, funding and delivery chain
Submission	Worksheet 3.1 by the start of Day 7.
Assessment	Feeds Gate 2. Feedback uses D1, D2, D3 and D5 and tracker code IN1.
Independent work	Find the most recent budget figure for the scheme or head that funds your problem, with year and source, and note it for your evidence register (which opens on Day 10). Check whether a CAG report, standing committee report or social audit has examined the service. About 45 minutes.
Essential reading	Pritchett, "Is India a Flailing State?" (2009), the opening sections.
Optional reading	Kapur, "Why Does the Indian State Both Fail and Succeed?" Journal of Economic Perspectives 34, no. 1 (2020).; The Constitution of India: the Seventh, Eleventh and Twelfth Schedules.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 35 | Concept: three kinds of power | | 35 to 55 | Demonstration: Madhyapur chain | | 55 to 85 | Activity: follow the money | | 85 to 110 | Own case: chain and funding | | 110 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 7: Actors and political economy

Week 2, Situate and prioritise · Tuesday

Central question. Who has power over this problem, what do they want, and who is not heard?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has built a power-interest and incentive matrix for your case that includes the groups with an interest but no voice.

Learning objectives.

1. Map actors by power over and interest in the outcome.
2. State each key actor's incentive and likely response to change.
3. Identify groups with high interest and little power or voice.
4. Explain how rules in use differ from rules on paper.

Element	Content
Competencies	D3, D4
Key concepts	Power-interest map; Incentives; Absent voices; Rules in use; Street-level discretion; Political economy analysis; Veto players
Anchor tool	Power-interest map with absent voices
Supporting tools	Incentive analysis; Political economy in four questions
Theory link	Elinor Ostrom and Michael Lipsky (Governing the Commons (1990); Street-Level Bureaucracy (1980)): Which rules actually govern behaviour here, and what will frontline workers really do?
Indian policy example	A congestion charge in an Indian city centre would affect car owners, bus users, vendors, traffic police and transport operators very differently. The people who gain most, bus commuters, are often the least organised.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur: the Commissioner, councillors and the contractor are high power and high interest; waste pickers, sanitation workers and residents near the landfill are high interest with little voice. Rule on paper: households must separate. Rule in use: the truck takes everything.
Live group activity	Stakeholder negotiation simulation: Experience how power, interest and incentives shape what is feasible, by negotiating a contested policy in role. (40 minutes)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 3.2, Stakeholder and incentive matrix
Submission	Worksheet 3.2 by the start of Day 8.
Assessment	Feeds Gate 2. Feedback uses D3 and D4 and tracker code IN2.
Independent work	Find one published source that records the experience of the absent voice in your case, such as a field study, a social audit, testimony to a committee or credible reporting. Note what it adds to your map. About 45 minutes.
Essential reading	Lipsky, Street-Level Bureaucracy (1980), preface and chapter 1, or the introduction to the expanded edition.
Optional reading	Ostrom, Governing the Commons (1990), chapter 3 on design principles.; Fritz, Kaiser and Levy, Problem-Driven Governance and Political Economy Analysis (World Bank, 2009), the framework section.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 30 | Concept: power, interest, incentives | | 30 to 45 | Demonstration: Madhyapur actors | | 45 to 85 | Activity: stakeholder negotiation | | 85 to 110 | Own case: incentive matrix | | 110 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 8: Prioritising issues

Week 2, Situate and prioritise · Wednesday

Central question. Given limited time, which parts of the problem deserve our attention first?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has pruned your issue tree by size of effect and ability to influence, and chosen the two or three branches you will analyse.

Learning objectives.

1. Rate branches by size of effect and ability to influence.
2. Prune low-priority branches with written reasons.
3. Distinguish prioritising issues from prioritising interventions.
4. Explain satisficing and what it means for a four-week analysis.

Element	Content
Competencies	B4
Key concepts	Pruning the tree; Size of effect; Ability to influence; Pareto reasoning; Bounded rationality; Satisficing
Anchor tool	Pruning matrix: size of effect against ability to influence
Supporting tools	Pareto reasoning; Equity check on pruning
Theory link	Herbert Simon (Administrative Behavior (1947) and later work on satisficing): Given limited time and attention, what is good enough to investigate, and what will you knowingly leave out?
Indian policy example	A municipal health department facing a dengue season cannot study every cause at once. Construction-site water, household storage, drains, reporting by private clinics and surveillance staffing differ both in likely effect and in how far the department can act on them.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur: analyse first, collection mixing and processing capacity; keep, narrowed, household space and know-how; quick check, monitoring; prune to context, national recycling prices.
Live group activity	The 80/20 challenge: Practise pruning under pressure, and defend what you dropped. (35 minutes)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 4.1, Pruning matrix
Submission	Worksheet 4.1 by the start of Day 9.
Assessment	Feeds Gate 2. Feedback uses B4 and tracker code ST2.
Independent work	For each priority branch, write the one or two questions that, if answered, would most change your recommendation. About 40 minutes.
Essential reading	Conn and McLean, Bulletproof Problem Solving (2018), the chapter on prioritisation and pruning the tree.
Optional reading	Simon, Herbert A. "A Behavioral Model of Rational Choice." Quarterly Journal of Economics 69, no. 1 (1955).

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 30 | Concept: pruning | | 30 to 50 | Demonstration: Madhyapur | | 50 to 85 | Activity: the 80/20 challenge | | 85 to 110 | Own case: pruning matrix | | 110 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 9: Hypotheses

Week 2, Situate and prioritise · Thursday

Central question. What do we currently believe explains the problem, and how could we prove ourselves wrong?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has written a hypothesis register with disconfirming evidence and rival explanations, and defended it in the Hypothesis Battle.

Learning objectives.

1. Write three to five testable hypotheses from your priority branches.
2. State, for each, the evidence that would weaken it.
3. Name a rival explanation and the evidence that would tell the two apart.
4. Separate assumptions from hypotheses and decide which to test first.

Element	Content
Competencies	F1, F2, F3
Key concepts	Falsifiability; Disconfirming evidence; Rival explanations; Confirmation bias; Assumption mapping; Confidence
Anchor tool	Hypothesis register
Supporting tools	Assumption mapping; Competing explanations
Theory link	None today.
Indian policy example	Low participation of women in paid work has several competing explanations in the Indian research literature, including care responsibilities, the availability of suitable local jobs, social norms, safety and transport, and household income. Several may be true at once, in different proportions in different places.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur H1: payment by weight leads crews to mix separated waste. Weakened if crews mix just as much under per-household or per-trip contracts. Rival: vehicles lack compartments whatever the payment. Discriminating evidence: cities with compartment vehicles but weight-based contracts.
Live group activity	The hypothesis battle: Defend a hypothesis against rivals, and learn to specify evidence that would tell them apart. (45 minutes (Thursday challenge))
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 4.2, Hypothesis register
Submission	Worksheet 4.2 by the start of Day 10, for Gate 2.
Assessment	Gate 2 (Day 10). Feedback uses F1, F2 and F3 and tracker codes HY1 and HY2.
Independent work	For each hypothesis, find one published source that could test it, and check that it covers your place and period. About 45 minutes.
Essential reading	Bardach and Patashnik, A Practical Guide for Policy Analysis, part I, step two: assemble some evidence.
Optional reading	Heuer, Richards J., Jr. Psychology of Intelligence Analysis. Center for the Study of Intelligence, 1999. Chapter 8, analysis of competing hypotheses.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 25 | Concept: testable hypotheses | | 25 to 40 | Demonstration: Madhyapur register | | 40 to 85 | Thursday challenge: hypothesis battle | | 85 to 110 | Own case: hypothesis register | | 110 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 10: The workplan

Week 2, Situate and prioritise · Friday

Central question. What exactly will we investigate, with which evidence, and by when?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has built a workplan linking each priority hypothesis to an analysis, a source and a deadline, opened your evidence register, and submitted Gate 2.

Learning objectives.

1. Turn each priority hypothesis into a research question.
2. Link each question to an analysis, a named source and a deadline.
3. Identify evidence gaps and decide how to handle them.
4. Open the evidence register.

Element	Content
Competencies	E1, E2
Key concepts	Workplan; Research question; Level and period of data; Evidence gaps; Proxies; Evidence register
Anchor tool	Workplan matrix: hypothesis, question, analysis, source, deadline
Supporting tools	Evidence gap analysis; The evidence register
Theory link	None today.
Indian policy example	The rural employment guarantee's management information system publishes extensive data on works, payments and delays, often richer than analysts expect. Knowing what a public system already publishes is part of designing a feasible workplan.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur: H1 contract, compare cities with different payment terms using published contracts, audits and case studies, by Day 13; H3 processing, set capacity against waste generated using the city's waste plan, by Day 12.
Live group activity	The missing data challenge: Design a feasible research plan when the ideal data do not exist. (25 minutes)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 4.3, Workplan and evidence register
Submission	Gate 2 (Worksheets 3.1, 3.2, 4.1, 4.2 and 4.3, revised) by the end of Day 10. Feedback returned by Day 12.
Assessment	Gate 2: detailed feedback on domains D, F and the first part of E (E1 and E2) under the five headings. Formative.
Independent work	Rest, then start the first analysis in your workplan. About 30 minutes.
Essential reading	The methods note or data documentation for the main dataset in your workplan: read how it was collected and at what level it is representative.
Optional reading	A PRS Legislative Research budget analysis for your sector or state.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 20 | Concept: from register to workplan | | 20 to 35 | Demonstration: Madhyapur workplan | | 35 to 60 | Activity: missing data challenge | | 60 to 100 | Gate 2: pod peer review | | 100 to 120 | Debrief and planning |

Day 11: Finding and judging evidence

Week 3, Investigate and synthesise · Monday

Central question. Where is the evidence on our problem, and how far can we trust it?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has entered and rated at least six sources in your evidence register.

Learning objectives.

1. Navigate the main kinds of Indian source, from surveys and administrative data to audits.
2. Judge a source by who produced it, how, when, at what level and with what limits.
3. Distinguish what a source establishes from what it only suggests.
4. Cite sources accurately in Chicago style, and never invent a detail.

Element	Content
Competencies	E2, E3, J5
Key concepts	Household surveys; Administrative data; Audit and oversight; Parliamentary sources; Reliability; Reference period and level; Chicago citation
Anchor tool	Source reliability assessment
Supporting tools	The Indian evidence ecosystem; Citing in Chicago style
Theory link	None today.
Indian policy example	A scheme dashboard, a CAG performance audit and a newspaper investigation can describe the same programme very differently. Dashboards record what the system reports; audits test records against practice; journalism documents particular places and voices.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur register entries: the 2016 rules (law, high); the city waste plan (official plan, medium, states intentions); ward returns (administrative, low to medium, self-reported); a state CAG audit of waste management (audit, high for its period).
Live group activity	The evidence hunt: Find and rank credible sources fast, and learn which kinds of source answer which kinds of question. (30 minutes)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 5.1, Building the evidence register
Submission	Updated evidence register by the start of Day 12.
Assessment	The evidence register is assessed with the final report (15 per cent). Gate 3 feedback uses E2, E3 and J5 and tracker codes EV1, EV2 and EV3.
Independent work	Read your two most important sources properly, including the methods section. Write three sentences on what each establishes and what it does not. About 50 minutes.
Essential reading	The methods chapter or note of your main survey or administrative source.
Optional reading	The CAG audit reports for your state and sector, searched on the CAG website.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 30 | Concept: the evidence ecosystem | | 30 to 45 | Demonstration: rating sources | | 45 to 75 | Activity: the evidence hunt | | 75 to 110 | Studio: own evidence register | | 110 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 12: What the numbers say

Week 3, Investigate and synthesise · Tuesday

Central question. What does the data actually tell us, and what does it not?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has produced three charts or tables that disaggregate or compare, each with an interpretation and a limitation.

Learning objectives.

1. Compute and read shares, rates, averages and changes correctly.
2. Disaggregate by place, group or time to find where the problem concentrates.
3. Choose a chart that suits the comparison, and label it honestly.
4. Separate what the numbers show from what they suggest.

Element	Content
Competencies	E4, I3, C5, J3
Key concepts	Shares, rates and averages; Percentage points and per cent; Denominators; Disaggregation; Missing data; Chart choice; False precision
Anchor tool	Disaggregation and comparison in a spreadsheet
Supporting tools	Choosing a chart; Correlation and causation; Avoiding false precision
Theory link	None today.
Indian policy example	District and state averages from surveys and dashboards often hide large differences between blocks, social groups and genders. Disaggregating is usually the single most informative step in an Indian policy analysis.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur (illustrative): separation by ward group, last year and this year. Finding: a sharp rise in planned colonies, little change elsewhere, incomplete data for informal settlements. Limitation: ward returns are self-reported.
Live group activity	Data detective: Find what a dataset can and cannot support, including the traps hidden in it. (30 minutes)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 5.2, Data analysis
Submission	Worksheet 5.2 by the start of Day 13.
Assessment	Feeds Gate 3. Feedback uses E4, I3, C5 and J3 and tracker codes CA2 and EV2.
Independent work	Finish your three charts. Ask your pod's evidence checker to review one chart for an honest scale and honest wording. About 50 minutes.
Essential reading	Spiegelhalter, David. The Art of Statistics: Learning from Data. London: Pelican, 2019. Chapter 1.
Optional reading	Schwabish, Jonathan. Better Data Visualizations. New York: Columbia University Press, 2021. The chapters on choosing a chart.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 30 | Concept: reading numbers | | 30 to 50 | Demonstration: Madhyapur data | | 50 to 80 | Activity: data detective | | 80 to 110 | Studio: own charts | | 110 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 13: Experience and comparison

Week 3, Investigate and synthesise · Wednesday

Central question. What can people's experience and other places' attempts tell us that numbers cannot?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has built a comparative case matrix and drawn themes from published qualitative sources.

Learning objectives.

1. Draw themes from published qualitative sources such as audits, social audits, testimony and field studies.
2. Compare how two or more places tackled a similar problem.
3. Identify the conditions that made an approach work, and which of them transfer.
4. Use qualitative evidence to test mechanisms, not just to illustrate.

Element	Content
Competencies	E5, E6
Key concepts	Qualitative evidence; Thematic coding; Independent sources; Comparative cases; Policy transfer; Form and function
Anchor tool	Comparative case matrix
Supporting tools	Coding published qualitative evidence into themes; Conditions for policy transfer
Theory link	None today.
Indian policy example	Indian cities have tried different routes to separated waste collection: Indore's citywide enforcement and campaigns, Pune's partnership with a waste pickers' cooperative, and Ambikapur's centres run by women's self-help groups. Each worked under particular conditions.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur compared with Indore, Pune and Ambikapur: the principle of paying for separated collection and partnering with organised waste pickers may transfer; Indore's scale of spending and sustained leadership may not.
Live group activity	The policy transfer challenge: Judge whether an intervention that succeeded elsewhere would work in a different context. (30 minutes)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 5.3, Comparative and qualitative evidence
Submission	Worksheet 5.3 by the start of Day 14.
Assessment	Feeds Gate 3. Feedback uses E5 and E6 and tracker code EV1.
Independent work	Prepare for the red team: write your three strongest findings so far, each with its two best sources. About 50 minutes.
Essential reading	Dolowitz, David P., and David Marsh. "Learning from Abroad: The Role of Policy Transfer in Contemporary Policy-Making." Governance 13, no. 1 (2000).
Optional reading	Andrews, Pritchett and Woolcock, Building State Capability (2017), on isomorphic mimicry, revisited.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 30 | Concept: qualitative evidence | | 30 to 50 | Demonstration: comparing cities | | 50 to 80 | Activity: policy transfer challenge | | 80 to 110 | Studio: own comparison | | 110 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 14: Testing the hypotheses

Week 3, Investigate and synthesise · Thursday

Central question. Which of our explanations survive the evidence?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has recorded a verdict for each hypothesis with its evidence, and responded in writing to a red team.

Learning objectives.

1. Weigh supporting and disconfirming evidence for each hypothesis.
2. Make arguments checkable with claim, evidence and warrant.
3. Record verdicts honestly: supported, weakened or unresolved.
4. Respond to challenge without overstating.

Element	Content
Competencies	F3, F5, E6, J4
Key concepts	Disconfirming evidence; Triangulation; Claim, evidence and warrant; Verdicts and confidence; Red teaming
Anchor tool	Hypothesis testing matrix
Supporting tools	Claim, evidence and warrant; Red team review
Theory link	None today.
Indian policy example	Evaluations of Indian programmes often find that the favoured explanation was partly right and a rival partly right too. Reporting that honestly is more useful to a decision-maker than a single tidy cause.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur (illustrative): H1, the contract, supported with the vehicle rival partly true; H2, containers, weakened; H3, processing, partly supported; H4, enforcement, the rival supported: fines alone backfire.
Live group activity	Red team review: Stress-test each analyst's strongest finding, and practise responding to challenge without overstating. (45 minutes (Thursday challenge))
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 6.1, Hypothesis testing matrix
Submission	Worksheet 6.1 by the start of Day 15, for Gate 3.
Assessment	Gate 3 (Day 15). Feedback uses F3, F5, E6 and J4 and tracker codes HY1 and JU1.
Independent work	Revise your diagnosis in the light of the verdicts. Draft the governing message for tomorrow's memo in one sentence. About 50 minutes.
Essential reading	Toulmin, Stephen. The Uses of Argument. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1958. The chapter on the layout of arguments.
Optional reading	Heuer, Psychology of Intelligence Analysis (1999), chapter 8, revisited.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 25 | Concept: weighing evidence | | 25 to 40 | Demonstration: Madhyapur verdicts | | 40 to 85 | Thursday challenge: red team review | | 85 to 110 | Own case: testing matrix | | 110 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 15: Synthesis and the diagnostic memo

Week 3, Investigate and synthesise · Friday

Central question. How do we turn a body of evidence into an argument a decision-maker can use?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has written a two-page diagnostic memo with a governing message, and submitted Gate 3.

Learning objectives.

1. Distinguish findings from insights.
2. Structure an argument top-down with the Pyramid Principle.
3. Open with Situation, Complication, Question and Answer.
4. Keep facts, inferences and assumptions visibly separate in the memo.

Element	Content
Competencies	I1, F4, J3
Key concepts	Findings and insights; Governing message; Key lines; Pyramid Principle; SCQA; Language that matches evidence
Anchor tool	Pyramid Principle with SCQA
Supporting tools	The executive summary; Rumelt's kernel of strategy
Theory link	Richard Rumelt (Good Strategy/Bad Strategy, 2011): Does your argument contain a diagnosis, a guiding policy and coherent action, or is it a list of goals?
Indian policy example	Senior Indian officials typically read briefs under severe time pressure, often between meetings. A note whose first paragraph states the answer and the decision required is far more likely to be acted on than one that builds slowly to its point.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur governing message: separation fails mainly at collection, because the contract pays for weight; campaigns alone will not fix it. Key lines: households respond to what crews do; crews respond to what they are paid for; downstream capacity decides whether separation is worthwhile.
Live group activity	The governing message race: Reduce a body of evidence to one defensible governing message and three key lines. (20 minutes)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 6.2, Diagnostic memo
Submission	Gate 3 (Worksheets 5.1 to 5.3 and 6.1, revised, and the memo) by the end of Day 15. Feedback returned by Day 17.
Assessment	Gate 3: detailed feedback on domains E and F and on I1, under the five headings. Formative.
Independent work	Rest. If you have time, read your memo aloud and cut every sentence the decision-maker would skip. About 30 minutes.
Essential reading	Minto, The Pyramid Principle, the chapters on the pyramid structure and on introductions (edition to confirm).
Optional reading	Rumelt, Good Strategy/Bad Strategy (2011), the chapter on the kernel of good strategy.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 25 | Concept: answer first | | 25 to 40 | Demonstration: Madhyapur pyramid | | 40 to 60 | Activity: governing message race | | 60 to 100 | Gate 3: pod peer review | | 100 to 120 | Debrief and planning |

Day 16: Generating options

Week 4, Decide, deliver, defend · Monday

Central question. How do we generate genuinely different options without jumping to the first attractive idea?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has generated at least three distinct options and a do-minimum baseline from a journey map of the affected group.

Learning objectives.

1. Map the affected group's journey using published evidence.
2. Frame How Might We questions at the points where the journey breaks.
3. Generate options that differ in mechanism, at different orders of change.
4. Screen options quickly on impact and effort, without choosing yet.

Element	Content
Competencies	G1, G2, C4
Key concepts	Journey map; How Might We; Ideation before judgement; Orders of change; Do-minimum baseline; Impact and effort screen; Desirability, feasibility, viability
Anchor tool	How Might We questions with a journey map
Supporting tools	Desirability, feasibility and viability; A quick impact and effort screen; Orders of change
Theory link	Peter Hall ("Policy Paradigms, Social Learning, and the State", Comparative Politics, 1993): Are you adjusting settings, changing instruments or changing goals?
Indian policy example	Options for access to primary healthcare in remote areas range from bringing care closer (outreach, telemedicine), to bringing people to care (transport), to changing who provides it (community health workers), to changing when people seek it. These are different mechanisms, not variations of one idea.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur: baseline (current contract and campaigns); A, pay for separated collection; B, partner with a waste pickers' cooperative for dry waste; C, a ward enforcement drive. A and B change instruments; C adjusts settings.
Live group activity	Policy innovation lab: Generate a wide set of genuinely different options for a common case before choosing any. (35 minutes)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 7.1, Options canvas
Submission	Worksheet 7.1 by the start of Day 17.
Assessment	Feeds the options appraisal and the client report. Feedback uses G1, G2 and C4 and tracker codes DE1 and DE2.
Independent work	For each option, find one published example of something similar being tried, in India or elsewhere, and note what happened. About 50 minutes.
Essential reading	Brown, Tim. "Design Thinking." Harvard Business Review, June 2008.
Optional reading	Hall, "Policy Paradigms, Social Learning, and the State" (1993), the section on orders of change.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 30 | Concept: options, not solutions | | 30 to 50 | Demonstration: Madhyapur options | | 50 to 85 | Activity: policy innovation lab | | 85 to 110 | Own case: options canvas | | 110 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 17: Choosing between options

Week 4, Decide, deliver, defend · Tuesday

Central question. Which option should we recommend, and why is it better than the alternatives?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has appraised your options against explicit criteria, estimated cost per outcome, tested sensitivity, applied the public value test, and chosen.

Learning objectives.

1. Choose and weight explicit criteria, including distribution and feasibility.
2. Score each option, and the baseline, with a reason for every score.
3. Estimate rough cost per unit of outcome and test whether the ranking depends on assumptions.
4. Test the preferred option for public value, legitimacy and support, and operational capacity.

Element	Content
Competencies	G3, G4, G5, J2
Key concepts	Criteria and weights; Multi-criteria decision analysis; Distributional analysis; Cost per outcome; Sensitivity; Public value; Incrementalism
Anchor tool	Options appraisal matrix with a distributional row
Supporting tools	Cost per outcome; Sensitivity testing; Moore's strategic triangle; Incremental and comprehensive choice
Theory link	Mark Moore, with Charles Lindblom (Creating Public Value (1995); "The Science of 'Muddling Through'" (1959)): Does the option create public value, can it win legitimacy and support, and is there the capacity to deliver it?
Indian policy example	Indian public decisions are rarely made on cost-effectiveness alone. Finance departments weigh cost, implementing departments weigh capacity, elected representatives weigh support, and affected groups weigh who gains and who pays. An appraisal that makes these criteria and their weights explicit is easier to defend.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur (illustrative): B scores 3.35, the baseline 3.15, A 3.00 and C 2.30. B is robust to the weights but sensitive to the cooperative's reach. Recommendation: B in ten pilot wards now, moving to A at contract renewal. Weakest leg: operational capacity.
Live group activity	The government decision committee: Defend options before officials who judge them by different criteria. (35 minutes)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 7.2, Options appraisal
Submission	Worksheet 7.2 by the start of Day 18. Pods check each other's appraisals in the last ten minutes of today's session; the instructor comments in writing before Day 18.
Assessment	Feeds the client report and the defence. A pod check of the appraisal ends today's session, with a written instructor comment before Day 18. Feedback uses G3, G4, G5 and J2 and tracker code DE3.
Independent work	Write your recommendation in one paragraph: what, by whom, by when, at what cost, and what it depends on. About 45 minutes.
Essential reading	Moore, Creating Public Value (1995), the chapter on defining public value.
Optional reading	Lindblom, "The Science of 'Muddling Through'" (1959).; Flyvbjerg and Gardner, How Big Things Get Done (2023), on reference-class forecasting.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 30 | Concept: criteria and weights | | 30 to 50 | Demonstration: Madhyapur appraisal | | 50 to 85 | Activity: decision committee | |

85 to 100 | Own case: options appraisal | | 100 to 110 | Pod check of appraisals | | 110 to 120 | Exit task |

Day 18: Designing for delivery

Week 4, Decide, deliver, defend · Wednesday

Central question. How does a good recommendation become a programme that actually works?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has built a theory of change, a responsibility matrix, a delivery approach and a risk register for your recommendation.

Learning objectives.

1. Build a theory of change and mark which links are evidenced and which are assumed.
2. Assign decision rights and responsibilities with RAPID or RACI, using named roles.
3. Choose whether to plan in full or build as you learn, and justify it.
4. Identify and plan for the main risks, including frontline responses.

Element	Content
Competencies	H1, H2, H3, H4
Key concepts	Theory of change; Inputs, activities, outputs, outcomes; Assumptions; Decision rights; RAPID and RACI; Classical and adaptive approaches; Problem-driven iterative adaptation; Risk register
Anchor tool	Theory of change
Supporting tools	RAPID or RACI; Strategy Palette with problem-driven iterative adaptation; Risk register
Theory link	Carol Weiss and Michael Lipsky (Theory-based evaluation (1995); Street-Level Bureaucracy (1980)): Which links in your theory of change are assumptions, and what will frontline workers actually do with the plan?
Indian policy example	Audits of Indian schemes frequently find that outputs were delivered but outcomes did not follow, or that frontline staff were reassigned (for example to election duty) at critical moments. A delivery design that anticipates these failures is part of the recommendation, not an afterthought.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur option B: inputs (funding, cooperative contract, sorting centres) to activities (pickers collect dry waste) to outputs (separate dry waste collection in pilot wards) to outcomes (households separate more; less to landfill). Key assumption: households respond to seeing separation respected. Approach: adaptive, ten-ward pilot with quarterly review.
Live group activity	Implementation breakdown simulation: Stress-test an implementation plan against the shocks real programmes face. (35 minutes)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 8.1, Implementation plan
Submission	Worksheet 8.1 by the start of Day 19.
Assessment	Feeds Gate 4 and the client report. Feedback uses H1 to H4 and tracker code EX1.
Independent work	Draft your full deck (10 to 12 slides) using the capstone structure; Gate 4 reviews it tomorrow. About 60 minutes.
Essential reading	Rogers and Blenko, "Who Has the D? How Clear Decision Roles Enhance Organizational Performance." Harvard Business Review (2006).
Optional reading	Reeves, Haanaes and Sinha, Your Strategy Needs a Strategy (2015), the chapter on the adaptive approach.; Andrews, Pritchett and Woolcock, Building State Capability (2017), on problem-driven iterative adaptation.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 30 | Concept: theory of change | | 30 to 50 | Demonstration: Madhyapur delivery | | 50 to 85 | Activity: implementation breakdown | | 85 to 110 | Own case: implementation plan | | 110 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 19: Measurement and the pitch

Week 4, Decide, deliver, defend · Thursday

Central question. How will we know whether the recommendation is working, and can we make the case in five slides?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has built an indicator framework, drafted your deck, rehearsed the five-slide pitch and submitted Gate 4.

Learning objectives.

1. Separate input, output and outcome indicators.
2. Give each indicator a source, a baseline requirement and a frequency, and disaggregate at least one.
3. Link the riskiest assumptions to early indicators and review points.
4. Build and rehearse a five-slide pitch with the recommendation in the first minute.

Element	Content
Competencies	H5, I2, I4
Key concepts	Inputs, activities, outputs, outcomes, impact; Indicator tree; SMART indicators; Baselines and targets; Disaggregation; Adaptive review; Argument titles; Policy windows
Anchor tool	Indicator framework (indicator tree)
Supporting tools	SMART indicators; Early warning and adaptive review; The five-slide pitch; Policy windows
Theory link	John Kingdon (Agendas, Alternatives, and Public Policies, 1984): Is there a window for this recommendation, and which stream is missing?
Indian policy example	Indian scheme dashboards often report outputs, such as toilets built, bins distributed or trainings held, because they are easy to count. Outcome indicators, such as use, behaviour and health, are harder to collect and are where programmes are truly judged.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur option B: outcome indicators (households separating by ward type; dry waste reaching landfill), output indicators (dry waste collected by the cooperative; pickers with contracts), and an early warning on the key assumption (separation in pilot wards after three months).
Live group activity	The five-slide challenge: Compress a complex analysis into a five-slide story with the recommendation first. (35 minutes (Thursday challenge))
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 9.1, Indicator framework and draft deck
Submission	Gate 4 (Worksheets 7.1, 7.2, 8.1 and 9.1, revised, with the draft deck) by the end of Day 19. Brief written feedback is returned before Day 20.
Assessment	Gate 4: brief written feedback on domains G and H and on the deck (I2), returned before Day 20. Formative.
Independent work	Rehearse your pitch twice, timed. Prepare answers to the five red team questions for your own case. About 60 minutes.
Essential reading	Kingdon, Agendas, Alternatives, and Public Policies, the chapter on the policy window.
Optional reading	The results framework or indicator list published for your scheme, if one exists: compare its indicators with yours.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 10 | Opening problem | | 10 to 30 | Concept: indicators | | 30 to 45 | Demonstration: Madhyapur indicators | | 45 to 80 | Thursday challenge: five-slide challenge | | 80 to 110 | Gate 4: rehearsal and peer review | | 110 to 120 | Debrief and exit task |

Day 20: The defence

Week 4, Decide, deliver, defend · Friday

Central question. Can you defend your analysis and recommendation before a decision-making panel?

Expected learning output. By the end of the session, each participant has presented your recommendation, defended it under questioning and contributed to your pod's synthesis.

Learning objectives.

1. Present your recommendation in six minutes, answer first.
2. Defend the evidence, assumptions and feasibility under questioning.
3. Concede uncertainty without abandoning the argument.
4. Draw lessons across your pod's cases.

Element	Content
Competencies	I4, I5, J2
Key concepts	Defence under questioning; Handling uncertainty; Cross-case synthesis; Reflection
Anchor tool	Panel presentation and defence
Supporting tools	The pod synthesis slide; Opening the sealed answer
Theory link	None today.
Indian policy example	Briefings to senior officials and ministers in India are often short and interrupted. Analysts who lead with the decision, answer the question asked and state uncertainty plainly are the ones whose work is used.
Worked example (Madhyapur)	Madhyapur: the panel's finance officer asks what happens if the cooperative reaches only half the wards. The report adds the sensitivity result (cost per household roughly doubles) and a decision rule at the first quarterly review.
Live group activity	The final boardroom presentation: Present and defend a recommendation before a decision-making panel, as in professional practice. (About 12 minutes per participant)
Individual workbook exercise	Worksheet 10.1, Capstone submission
Submission	Client report, final deck, evidence register, reflection and AI disclosure within 72 hours of the end of Day 20.
Assessment	Presentation and defence: 15 per cent, individual. Pod synthesis: 5 per cent. Client report: 20 per cent. Evidence register: 15 per cent. Workbook portfolio: 35 per cent, assessed after submission.
Independent work	Write and submit the capstone within 72 hours. Use the panel's questions: the report should answer each of them.
Essential reading	None set.
Optional reading	Your own Analyst Development Tracker: read the codes that recurred across the four gates before writing the report.

Session plan. | Minutes | Block | |---|---| | 0 to 5 | Panel briefing | | 5 to 95 | Presentations and defence | | 95 to 107 | Pod synthesis slides | | 107 to 115 | Sealed answers returned | | 115 to 120 | Close |